Inclusive Language

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What is it for?

Inclusive language means using words that respect everyone. It avoids words that leave out, sideline, or put down groups of people, for example, because of disability, race, gender, sexuality, age, or wealth.

- Ableist language (e.g., 'lame', 'crazy', 'blind spot') uses disability as a negative metaphor
- Biased or gendered terms (e.g., 'salesman', 'guys') can exclude people
- Overly complex jargon or idioms can be significant barriers
- Using labels (e.g., 'the disabled') defines people by their condition

How to support it

- Use person-first language (e.g., 'a person with vision loss') unless people prefer identity-first (e.g., 'an autistic person'), as the Deaf community generally does
- Avoid ableist metaphors. Instead of 'fell on deaf ears', say 'the feedback was ignored'
- Use neutral terms like 'everyone', 'team', or 'you all' instead of 'guys'
- Be specific and clear. Avoid jargon and write in plain language

Useful Links

Home Office Design System: Inclusive language

Harder than you think: developing an inclusive language guide

The Quick Guide to Inclusive Language